Center for Economic Research on Governance, Inequality and Conflict
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Kenza ELASS

Postdoctoral researcher at ENS de Lyon - Center for Economic Research on Governance, Inequality and Conflict (CERGIC)

Research Fields

Labour Economics, Applied Econometrics, Urban Economics, Public and Digital Economics

Current position

Since 10/2025 **Postdoctoral fellow**, *ENS de Lyon*, Center for Economic Research on Governance, Inequality and Conflict, Research Fellow of the Gender Lab of Bocconi.

Academics

2023-2025 **Postdoctoral fellow**, *Bocconi University*.
- Sponsored by Paola Profeta, supported by the Future Artificial Intelligence Research (FAIR) foundation

2022-2023 **PhD Research Fellow**, *Paris School of Economics*, Labour Chair.
- Sponsored by Dominique Meurs and Eric Maurin
- 4th Year PhD Dissertation Scholarship

2019-2023 **PhD candidate in Economics**, *Aix-Marseille School of Economics*.
- **Supervisors**: Cecilia García-Peñalosa (AMSE, CNRS, EHESS) & Christian Schluter (AMSE)
- **Title:** Supply side effects on gender wage inequality

2017 - 2019 **Master in Economics**, *Aix-Marseille School of Economics*, with honors, specialised in Data Science.

2014 - 2017 **Bachelor's in Economics**, *Aix-Marseille School of Economics*, 1st and 2nd year attended at Université Lille 1, specialised in Data Science.

2017 **Exchange program**, *Udem - University of Montréal*, Canada, with honors.

Research Visits

2022 - 2023 **Paris School of Economics**, Labour Chair.

May 2022 **CREST, ENSAE**, *Institut Polytechnique de Paris*, sponsored by Roland Rathelot.

April 2022 **Paris School of Economics**, Labour Chair, sponsored by Dominique Meurs.

February and March 2022 **Bocconi University**, AXA Research Lab on Gender Equality, sponsored by Paola Profeta.

Publication

"Male and female selection effects on gender wage gaps in three countries" (single-authored) - **Labour Economics** - https://doi.org/10.1016/j.labeco.2024.102506

Abstract: *A vast literature on gender wage gaps has examined the importance of selection into employment. However, most analyses have focused only on female labour force participation and gaps at the median. The Great Recession questions this approach because of the major shift in male employment that it implied. This paper uses the methodology proposed by Arellano and Bonhomme (2017) to estimate a quantile selection model over the period 2007-2018. Using*

a tax and benefit microsimulation model, I compute an instrument capturing both male and female decisions to participate in the labour market: the potential out-of-work income. Since my instrument is crucially determined by the welfare state, I consider three countries with notably different benefit systems – the UK, France and Finland. My results imply different selection patterns across countries and a sizeable male selection in France and the UK. Correction for selection bias lowers the gender wage gap and reveals a substantial glass ceiling with different magnitudes. Findings suggest that disparities between these countries are driven by occupational segregation and public spending on families.

Working Papers

"Automating Inequality: Gender Bias in AI-mediated Labor Markets", with Germain Gauthier (Bocconi University), Debora Nozza (Bocconi University) & Paola Profeta (Bocconi University) - **Accepted at PNAS**
Link to the AEA Pre-analysis Plan

Abstract: *Generative AI is rapidly entering labor markets, with large language models (LLMs) now used to help write CVs and evaluate applicants. We study the risks this creates in a series of audit experiments in which applicant gender is randomly assigned while all other information is held constant. We find that LLMs generate gender-stereotypical CVs and exhibit gender bias in screening scores and wage recommendations. Screening disparities are larger in more gender-segregated occupations, while wage disparities track occupational gender wage gaps. These disparities arise through two channels: evaluation bias, when identical CV content is evaluated differently by gender, and generation bias, when gendered content produced by the model affects later evaluation. Because the same systems shape both CV content and its subsequent assessment, these channels typically reinforce each other. Taken together, our findings identify measurable risks of algorithmic amplification in AI-mediated job search.*

"What do women want in a job? Household constraints, gender-biased preferences and the reservation wage gap" (Job Market Paper) *This paper was awarded the* ***Etta Chiuri Prize 2025*** *by the Italian Society of Public Economics, the* ***Young Researcher Prize*** *at the 5th Workshop in Gender and Economics (University of Luxembourg), and was runner-up for the Distinguished CESifo Affiliate Award in Labor Economics*

Abstract: *Recent explanations of the gender wage gap emphasize the role of gender differences in job search, yet the role of household constraints remains underexplored. This paper uses French administrative data to investigate the importance of gender-specific decisions in the reservation wage gap, and specifically how household constraints shape women's reservation wage strategies. First, I assess the types of occupations that men and women apply for and the implications for the reservation wage gap. Using textual analysis, I create a novel dataset classifying occupations based on temporal flexibility and job content. Quantile decomposition methods allow me to document an unequal gap in reservation wage, intensifying along the distribution, partially explained by gender biased choices in the amenities of the desired job. I then assess to which extent a 2018 reform, which increased childcare benefits for single-parent households by 30%, influenced the reservation wage and job-search behaviour. Using a difference-in-difference strategy and spatial variation in childcare service availability, results indicate that the reduction in childcare costs led women to lower their reservation wages. I also find that more affordable access to flexible childcare increases the likelihood of targeting occupations requiring greater temporal flexibility and the desired maximum commute, thereby enabling them to secure more stable jobs upon re-employment.*

"Gender Gaps in the Urban Wage Premium", with Cecilia García-Peñalosa (AMSE, CNRS, EHESS) & Christian Schluter (AMSE) - Link to the CEPR Working Paper, Link to the CESifo Working Paper

Abstract: *We examine the economic geography of gender wage gaps to understand the role that location plays in gender earning differences. Using panelised administrative data for the universe of French workers, our findings indicate that women benefit relatively more from density than men, with an urban wage premium (return to urban density) 48% higher than for men. We identify a number of factors that explain this gap, with a large share being explained by the structure of the local labour market, notably, the extent of occupational segregation. Another important factor is commuting patterns, while childcare availability plays only a moderate role.*

Selected research papers in progress

"Generative AI's algorithmic bias on the labour market", With Max Thon (University of Zurich) and Paola Profeta (Bocconi University)

"Beyond borders: The impact of women's migration on French native labour market outcomes", With Lydia Assouad (Harvard, LSE) and Cecilia Garcia Penalosa (Aix-Marseille School of Economics)

Other writing - General audience

"Threat or opportunity? The impact of AI on women", with Paola Profeta (Bocconi University) - *Link to the paper*

Research Activities

Invited Talks

2027 Innovation Seminar Collège de France - INSEAD*

2026 Stockholm Institute of Transition Economics (SITE) - Gender gaps in the AI economy workshop, Labour Seminar Series at Aalto University*

2025 Workshop in Gender Economics at ENS de Lyon, Discrimination and the Inequalities in the Age of AI Workshop at Sciences Po

2024 ECONtribute and C-SEB Design & Behavior Seminar at Cologne University, CREM Seminar at Rennes University

Conferences and Workshops

2026 ADRES 2026 Conference, 2nd Workshop for Early Career Women in Economic Geography & Spatial Economics at LSE, 5th Workshop in Gender and Economics, Gender gaps in the AI economy Conference, CESifo Area Conference on Labor Economics, CESifo Venice Summer Institute

2025 Workshop "Gender Gaps and Social Norms" of Pompeu Fabra, Bank of Italy Gender Economics Workshop, TASKS VII Conference: The Economic Impacts of AI on Work and Labor Markets, 4th Workshop on Field Experiments in Economics and Business, 10th CEPR Text-As-Data Workshop, SIEP Conference, 2025 Workshop in Gender Economics at ENS de Lyon, 5th Discrimination and Diversity Workshop, LAGV 2025, MESIE CEPR Workshop, Gender inequality workshop at the London School of Economics, Discrimination and the Inequalities in the Age of AI Workshop at Sciences Po, Advanced AI Methods Workshop at Bocconi

2024 ADRES 2024, Afépop 2024, Junior Research Day 2024, Junior Economist Meeting 2024, COSME workshop, 3rd Workshop on Public Policies, Urban Economics Association Conference 2024, IAAE Conference 2024, EEA-ESEM 2024, EALE 2024

2023 ADRES 2023, 2023 Conference in Applied Econometrics using Stata, JMA 2023, AFSE 2023, LAGV 2023, ECINEQ 2023, GRAPE 2023 - Gender Gaps Conference, EALE 2023, King's Junior research day 2023

2022 EDGE Jamboree Conference, European Association of Labour Economists Conference 2022 (EALE), International Association for Applied Econometrics (IAAE) Conference 2022, LAGV 2022, JMA 2022, 4th Queen Mary University of London Economics and Finance Workshop for PhD & Post-doctoral Students, 2022 French Stata conference in applied econometrics, and Workshop on Labour Economics 2022 (IAAEU).

2021 9th ECINEQ Conference (London School of Economics), ECINEQ PhD Workshop (London School of Economics)

Seminars

2025 Applied Economics Lunch Seminar of PSE

2024 Areena JMC Symposium, Dondena AI and Society Initiative Seminar at Bocconi University, Food for Thought Seminar at Bocconi University, Labour Chair seminar at the Paris School of Economics

2023 Applied Economics Lunch seminar at the Paris School of Economics, PhD seminar at the Aix-Marseille School of Economics, Labour Chair seminar at the Paris School of Economics, Bocconi Food for Thought seminar

2022 Food for Thought seminar at Bocconi University, AMSE PhD seminar, seminar of the Labor Chair at the Paris School of Economics, Firms and market seminar at CREST, Core Brown Bag Seminar at Louvain University

2021 PhD seminar (Aix-Marseille School of Economics)

2020 Empirical & Econometric Methods Sessions (Aix-Marseille School of Economics), PhD seminar (Aix-Marseille School of Economics)

Academic Responsibilities

Jan.–Jul. 2027* **CNRS AISSAI Thematic Semester on AI in Economics**, *Co-PI & Organizer*, CERGIC, ENS de Lyon, 150,000€.
Coordination of a semester-long research program including invited seminars, workshops, and academic events on AI.

2023 - Now **AFÉPOP network**, *Co-organisation of the AFÉPOP conference and communication management*, https://afepop.fr/.

2024 - Now **Network WISPPRH x Gender Lab Bocconi x NYU Abu Dhabi of researchers in Gender Economics**, *Co-organisation of the 2025 and 2026 Workshop*, Workshop's Link.

2026 - Now **Organization of the Graduate Seminar**, CERGIC, ENS de Lyon, FR.
Weekly seminar in which PhD students present their ongoing research.

2023 - 2025 **AXA Gender Lab, Bocconi University**, *Co-organisation of the seminar series.*

2023 **Ecineq PhD Workshop & Mentoring session**, *Organisation of the online workshop and of mentoring sessions with senior faculties during the 2023 Ecineq Conference.*

2021 - 2022 **Selected topics on PhD and research**, *Co-organisation of sessions with senior faculty for the PhD program*, Aix-Marseille School of Economics.

2020 - 2022 **Organization of the PhD Seminar**, Aix-Marseille School of Economics, FR.

2020 - 2021 **Organization of the *Informal talks and PhD Advice discussion series***, Aix-Marseille School of Economics, FR.

Scientific Dissemination

Newspapers: La Repubblica, Il Sole 24 ore

Other media outlets: Italian Federation of Insurance Company Directors (FIDIA), Nada es Gratis

Outreach & Public Engagement:

- Presentation on labor market inequalities, *Cordées de la Réussite* (French national outreach program promoting higher education access for high school students from underrepresented

backgrounds), High-school La Martinière

- Expertise on gender gaps in labor markets, *Les Entreprises s'Engagent* (French public-private initiative promoting corporate social and gender equality commitments, co-founded by the Ministry of Labor and French Employment Services), Working Group on Women and Employment

Refereeing

Refereed journal articles for: Labour Economics, Journal of Economic Inequality, CESifo Economic Studies, Economics & Statistics, Review of Economics of the Household

Refereed conference articles for: Ecineq PhD Workshop 2023, European Association of Young Economists (EAYE) 2025 (King's College London), European Association of Young Economists (EAYE) 2026 (University of the Basque Country)

Awards and Grants

2027 **CNRS AISSAI Thematic Semester on AI in Economics**, *CNRS*, Co-PI, for a semester-long research programme hosted at CERGIC, ENS de Lyon, 150 000 euros.

2026 **Young Researcher Prize**, *5th Workshop in Gender and Economics (Univ. of Luxembourg)*, for the working paper "What do women want in a job?", 1 000 euros.

2026 **Runner-up**, *Distinguished CESifo Affiliate Award in Labor Economics*, for the working paper "What do women want in a job?".

2025 **Etta Chiuri Prize 2025**, *Italian Society of Public Economics*, for the working paper "What do women want in a job?", 2 500 euros.

2024 **Women and Science Chair Grant**, *Dauphine University*, for the project "Generative AI and labor market discrimination", 10 000 euros.

2022-2023 **Dissertation Scholarship**, *Labour Chair*, Paris School of Economics.

2019-2022 **PhD grant**, *Aix-Marseille University*, Aix-Marseille School of Economics.

2019 **Winner of the master dissertation award**, *Institut du Genre*, 500 euros.

2018 **Winner of the Special Mention of the Jury**, *Cercle des économistes*, La Parole aux Etudiants, co-written with Sarah VINCENT.

Teaching

2026 **Labour Economics**, *Undergraduate - en, 3rd year*, ENS de Lyon, FR.
Lecturer

2026 **LLMs for Academic Research**, *Invited Lecture / Module*, Lyon Summer School in Empirical Research Methods, ENS de Lyon.
Module on the use of large language models as research tools in economics.

2025 **Gender Economics**, *Graduate - en, Master 1*, ENS de Lyon, FR.
Lecturer

2025 **Gender Economics**, *Undergraduate - en, 2nd year*, Sciences-Po, FR.
Lecturer

2019 - 2021 **Microeconomics**, *Undergraduate-fr, 1st year*, Aix-Marseille University, FR.

2019 - 2020 **Econometrics of Qualitative Dependent Variables**, *Undergraduate-fr, 3rd year*, Aix-Marseille School of Economics, FR.

Mentoring and supervision

2026 **Master thesis supervision**, *Marie Guerro and Félix Lenoel*, ENS de Lyon.

2023 - Now **Mentoring Activities**, *Mentoring and supervision of Gender Lab's research assistant and master students interns, as well as Master dissertations at ENS de Lyon.*

Other information

Data Science: Python, R, SAS, Stata, Matlab
Microsimulation model: OpenFisca, EUROMOD
Citizenship: French
Languages: French (native), English (Fluent)

References

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